Ysbyty Gwynedd

Post Epidural Infusion / Injection Patient Instruction Leaflet/ Discharge Instructions

Introduction

Serious complications from epidural analgesia are **rare (1 in 10,000)**. Because the epidural space is close to the spinal cord a collection of pus, or a blood clot can cause pressure on the spinal cord. In the **unlikely event** that there is pressure on the spinal cord it is crucial to diagnose and treat it as quickly as possible; this must be done by expert hospital doctors to prevent delays in treatment and long-lasting damage. This leaflet tells you what to look for and what action to take if you think that you have a problem.

Assessment before the removal of epidural catheter

At the end of treatment with your epidural infusion the team of doctors and nurses caring for you will examine you to ensure that you do not have any residual numbness or weakness of your legs from the action of the drugs in your epidural infusion. They will ask to you move your legs and examine you to make sure that the sensation in your legs is as it was before the operation. It is important to remember that some operations can cause altered sensation in the legs therefore any changes experienced may be as a result of the surgery and not the epidural. If you do have altered sensation when the epidural is removed the attending team can discuss this with you.

If you experience any of the listed **signs and symptoms** (see list below) as a new problem, after your epidural infusion has been stopped as an inpatient ask the nurse in charge of the ward to contact the Pain Team or on call anaesthetist immediately.

If you have been discharged it is important that you contact the on call anaesthetist at the hospital **immediately** (Telephone 01248 384 384 and ask the switchboard operator to **bleep 063 or 551**). After speaking to the on call Anaesthetist they will arrange to see you in the Accident and Emergency department in order to examine you.

Signs and symptoms

- Redness, pus, tenderness, or pain at the epidural wound site
- Feeling generally unwell despite the fact that all seems to be well with the surgical wound
- High temperature, neck stiffness
- Numbness and or weakness in your legs / inability to weight bear
- Difficulty passing water / incontinence of faeces

Further Information

For further information on this subject, please contact: Pain Nurse Specialist on01248 384 384, Ext 4177or Bleep 115.